Nikolytics
Operating Manual

Version: 1.0 draft, 2026-07-04. Pending Nikola's review; treat every section as binding once this line is removed.
Distribution: internal and contracted partners only (team, referral partners, marketing agency, website team). Do not forward to prospects or publish any part of it. Facts marked "publish-gated" or "NDA" have additional rules stated where they appear.
Companion document: the Founder Appendix (internal financial detail) is separate and private. If a number you need is not in this manual, ask Nikola; do not estimate.

1. What this document is

This is the operating manual for Nikolytics' current chapter: the July 2026 rebuild of the company around one premium flagship service for the US market. It exists so that anyone working with us (an employee, a referral partner, a lead-sourcing contractor, a marketing agency, a web developer) can understand what we sell, to whom, how we get clients, how we deliver, and the principles behind our decisions, without needing a call to explain it.

How to read it by role

You are	Read at minimum
Anyone, first day	Sections 1, 2, 3, 10, 13 (glossary)
Lead sourcing / outreach	Sections 3, 4, 5, 6, 12
Marketing agency	Sections 3, 4, 5, 9, 10, 12
Website team	Sections 3, 4, 9, 12
Delivery / engineering	Sections 4, 7, 8, 10
Referral partners	Sections 3, 4, 5.4, 10

Rules that govern this document

1. **Single source of truth.** If another document, message, or memory contradicts this manual, this manual wins until the decision log says otherwise. Decisions are made by Nikola, logged in the decision log, and then reflected here.
2. **Facts are labeled.** Every number in this manual is one of: a **decision** (we chose it), a **verified fact** (it happened and we can show it), a **planning assumption** (best available guess, replace with measured data), or **publish-gated / NDA** (true, with restrictions on use). Section 12 carries the full table. We have close to zero empirical marketing data today; treating assumptions as facts is how documents rot, so we do not do it.
3. **Style, for every document and public word we produce:** plain and direct. No hype, no dramatic constructions, no book-style theatrics. The word "MVP" is banned from all copy (it anchors us to the $4k-$25k tier we do not compete in). Em dashes are not used in any document.
4. **Honesty is enforced through mechanics.** Real caps, published fill levels, no fabricated or implied proof, no invented statistics. The details are in Section 10.

2. The company

Nikolytics, founded and run by Nikola Popović. The company builds custom software platforms. It has active clients, real deliveries, and revenue, and is in a deliberate rebuild started July 2026: from selling automations toward one premium flagship, positioned for funded US startups.

What changed in the rebuild:

- **One flagship service** (Section 4). The four former service lines were consolidated: software platforms are the flagship; web work and automations became bonuses inside it; consulting lives inside the Growth Architecture Sessions bonus and the Founding Partner tier. Ad-hoc cheap integrations are no longer sold standalone.
- **One brand.** Nikolytics only. Sub-brands (NykoWeb, NykoSoft and similar) were considered and rejected.
- **Automation was demoted, not abandoned**: too simple and too cheap to lead with while AI makes it a commodity. It survives as the Back-Office Autopilot Suite bonus.

Track record, stated plainly: roughly five platforms built to date, largely by Nikola personally. Current delivered work includes a $250,000 platform build for American Paragons (launched and live, Section 12), two paid integrations for sports-tech companies, and one large platform engagement under NDA that is never referenced publicly or privately outside this company.

The current steering metric: close, deliver, and document the first client acquired through the new system. There is deliberately no 12-month revenue target yet; building a machine that demonstrably works comes first. Every plan in this manual serves that one outcome.

Financial rule #1: we spend only collected cash. No marketing plan, hire, or tool purchase spends money that has not landed in the account. Client payment structures front-load cash (Section 4, Terms) so that growth funds itself.

3. Who we serve

The avatar: funded US startup founders, seed to Series B, who need a custom software platform built, in the $50,000 to $500,000 deal band.

Their situation, in plain terms: they raised money and promised a product. What they have is a no-code stack cracking under real users, an offshore quote they cannot verify, or an agency proposing months of discovery. Their launch date has consequences attached: a board meeting, design partners, a pilot, the next raise. They cannot spend their days project-managing a dev shop, because they are running the company and often the raise.

Why this market passes the four criteria: the pain is real and worsening as the launch window closes; purchasing power is definitional (they are funded); they are targetable (Crunchbase, YC directories, VC portfolio pages, LinkedIn filters, founder communities); and the pool grows every funding cycle.

Who we do not serve, and say so early:

- Buyers shopping for the cheapest build. Our price is fixed and public in conversation: $250,000. We are eliminated quickly and that is the intended function.
- Founders who want to buy hours and manage a vendor. We sell a launched platform, with the client's involvement capped by design.
- Pre-funding, pre-urgency founders. We stay polite, we stay findable, and we do not spend sales time here.

Parked segments (do not pursue, do not delete):

- **Foundations.** Nikola's hypothesis: foundations need platforms and are run by wealthy people who would use the saved time to advance their cause. They are problem-unaware, which makes them an education-first market. Parked until Nikolytics has an established social-media presence capable of that education. Logged 2026-07-04.
- **General premium-platform buyers** (non-startup businesses that can pay). Plausible, unvalidated, secondary.

The demand premise is unvalidated, and we treat that seriously. Market research (July 2026) could not verify the rate at which funded startups outsource core platform builds; every strong public statistic on it failed verification. Our own pipeline (roughly $870k in closed and quoted work) is currently the best demand evidence we have. Consequence, adopted as policy: **the first 100 sales conversations are also a demand-validation study.** Every conversation logs four things: (1) what triggered their interest, (2) their objections, (3) how they found and chose their last dev partner, (4) how they found us. This log is reviewed monthly as a research instrument.

4. What we sell

One product family, four named offers, one ladder. Nothing else is advertised or sold.

Offer	Price	Role
The Launch-Risk Teardown	free to $5,000 (laddered)	Diagnostic lead magnet, entry conversation
The Blueprint	$25,000	Paid scoping sprint; entry offer and natural downsell
The Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint	**$250,000 fixed**	The flagship
The Founding Partner Build	$1,500,000, one client per year	Anchor tier

Post-delivery offers (the Traction Block and the Product Engine) exist and are staged behind capacity gates; they are described in Section 8.

4.1 The flagship: the Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint

The promise: a full custom platform, live in production, on infrastructure the client owns outright, within 30 days of kickoff.

The price: $250,000, fixed. It never discounts, for anyone, ever. When a deal needs sharpening, we add value; we do not subtract price. (Why: a discount given once makes every future price a negotiation, and the offer's credibility rests on the number meaning what it says.)

Positioning spine: certainty, carried by pressure transfer. The emotional core of this service is that the founder hands over the build and we carry the weight: their time commitment is under an hour a day, in writing. Every marketing claim of that kind must immediately be backed by the specific mechanism that makes it true (the terms below), because "worry-free, we handle everything" is the emptiest sentence in this industry until a contract term proves it.

The stack, itemized at $465,000 of stated value. These valuations are chosen positioning with stated justifications, not market prices; each item exists because it deletes one documented way platform builds fail:

#	Stack item	Stated value	The fear it deletes
1	Boardroom Business Case: ROI model on their raise metrics, loaded-cost comparison, the Cheap Build Teardown, board-ready one-pager	$15,000	"My board will ask why we outsourced our core product"
2	Head-to-Blueprint Sprint: extraction sessions, co-signed spec, clickable prototype, auditable architecture doc, the Acceptance Checklist	$35,000	"The flow I forget becomes the feature you skip"
3	Locked-Number Charter: ambiguity resolves in the client's favor, two Swap Tokens for mid-build feature swaps	$25,000	"Every fixed quote balloons"

#	Stack item	Stated value	The fear it deletes
4	The Glass Box Build: named senior engineers with a no-substitution clause, live staging URL from day 3 deployed daily, daily 3-minute demo video, Integration War Room in week 1, milestone dashboard	$300,000	"I wired six figures to people I cannot verify"
5	One-Hour-a-Day Founder Protocol: asset concierge, A/B/C design reviews, three fixed decision gates, we do the QA	$20,000	"I cannot moonlight as your PM"
6	Day-One Keys Protocol: everything created under the client's logins from day one, full IP assignment, stranger-readable docs, Migration Without Casualties	$18,000	"Am I a hostage? What if they fold?"
7	Open-Ledger Quality Pack: independent third-party code audit at handoff, test suite and CI the client watches, security questionnaire pack, SOC 2-ready checklist	$30,000	"30 days must mean cut corners"
8	Launch Command: production deploy, monitoring pointed at their phone, 10x load test with report, cost-at-scale projection, launch-week on-call	$22,000	"Who watches my product at 2am on day one"

Terms, always presented in this order:

1. **Founder's Full-Send: 100% at signing.** The price does not move; prepay carries $85,000 of added value: the Evergreen Codebase Plan doubles from 12 to 24 months (+$50,000) and the Momentum Sprint attaches (+$35,000: one post-launch feature week at full build speed within 90 days, booked into a real open slot).
2. **Builder's Split: 54% / 26% / 20%.** $135,000 at signing; $65,000 at the day-14 staging milestone (an objective, dated event: a working demo of the checklist-mapped core flows); $50,000 at go-live against the co-signed Acceptance Checklist, with a deemed-acceptance clause (5 business days to dispute specific items in writing, then the balance is due). The deposit reason is stated openly to clients: a signature takes a named senior team off the market for a month, so commitment is symmetrical.

The Live-in-30 Guarantee, quoted verbatim (contract artifact):

> "If your platform is not live in production, on infrastructure you own, passing every item on the Acceptance Checklist we co-signed at Blueprint approval, within 30 days of kickoff, we keep the full named team on your build for free until it passes, your 60-day Founders' Shield extends to 180 days at zero cost, and on the split plan your final $50,000 stays in your account until the day it passes."

There is no money-back guarantee, and we say why to the client's face: we front a named senior team, and we only work with founders committed enough to launch. The guarantee has four conditions, which are simply the client actions that produce a launch: checklist signed before kickoff; requested assets and access within 48 hours; one named decision-maker with feedback at the three gates within 1 business day; no net-new scope beyond the two Swap Tokens. A missed condition pauses the clock; it never voids the guarantee. Third-party delays outside anyone's control pause it for both sides.

Bonuses: $297,000 stated value, revealed after the yes (in live conversations; on the website they are listed, because a page cannot shake hands first). Each crushes one objection: the Launch-Day Conversion Site & Animation Suite ($40k), Back-Office Autopilot Suite ($35k), Founders' Shield 60-day warranty with a named maintenance engineer ($45k), Evergreen Codebase Plan 12 months ($50k), In-House Handoff Week ($18k), Enterprise-Ready Compliance Pack ($25k), Growth Architecture Sessions with Nikola ($30k), Continuity Vault escrow ($12k), ROI Instrumentation Pack ($20k), and the kickoff-locked Launch Concierge Command ($22k, attaches only on signing by the Thursday before kickoff). The nine always-on bonuses total $275,000, so the bonus layer alone exceeds the price in every scenario. Presentation rule: ask for the sale first; on a no, deploy exactly one bonus against the stated obstacle, then ask again.

Scarcity and urgency, both real:

- **Three concurrent build slots, total.** This is the real capacity of a senior-only bench and the reason the 30 days holds. Fill level is published on the site and stated on every call. When full: a numbered waitlist with a 72-hour first-right-of-refusal window per slot. Slots are never oversold. Blueprint holders have waitlist priority.
- **Cohort kickoffs on the first and third Monday of every month**, because kickoff choreography is batched. Sign by Thursday, start Monday. A missed cohort is sold as prep time, never discounted.

4.2 The Blueprint ($25,000)

The flagship's scoping phase sold standalone: extraction sessions, co-signed spec, clickable prototype, auditable architecture document, and the Acceptance Checklist, delivered by the people who would build it. **100% of the $25,000 credits toward a build signed within 60 days.** Maximum 2 concurrent Blueprints so they never starve a live build. It is the entry offer, the natural downsell, and the honest answer to "we are not ready to commit $250k": commit $25k, get something independently valuable, keep the credit.

Why it is paid rather than free: a paid diagnostic filters for buyers who can afford a $250,000 conversation, and show rates on paid engagements are dramatically higher. It competes against free scope calls at cheaper shops; that is accepted and intended.

4.3 The Founding Partner Build ($1,500,000, one per year)

Nikola personally leads the build; unlimited Swap Tokens; 12 months of embedded iteration by a dedicated senior team that occupies one of the three build slots for the full term (which is exactly why only one exists per year); board-meeting attendance; direct access to Nikola. Full consulting access lives here. It is mentioned in every flagship conversation. It exists to be real, to be sold rarely, and to make $250,000 read as the reasonable middle. Website visibility: undecided (open item).

4.4 Naming rules

- The product name is **the Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint**. It appears in contracts, on the site, and in the glossary. It does not change with marketing fashion.
- Outbound hooks and headlines ("wrappers") rotate and get tested. Current direction: pressure-transfer language backed by mechanisms. Rejected: "The One-Hour-a-Day Platform Build" (ambiguous about whose hour). "Board-Proof" phrasing stays in the rotation for testing. "Ship While They Scope" is reserved as an aggressive later-stage hook.

- No name or headline may pair a dollar figure with a time promise (implied-guarantee compliance rule). Durations are fine; quantified dollar claims next to them are not.

4.5 Delivery reality behind the promise (why 30 days is honest)

Internal target: **ship in roughly 2 weeks; promise 30 days.** The buffer absorbs client feedback rounds and third-party surprises, and means clients experience early delivery rather than deadline drama. The mechanics that make it possible: prebuilt, hardened infrastructure modules (auth, billing, admin, deploy pipelines) that we reuse and the client owns; the spec and prototype signed before kickoff so nobody discovers the product mid-build; a senior-only bench that is never spread thin; and scope locked by the Acceptance Checklist plus two Swap Tokens. Nikola has built roughly five platforms, largely single-handedly; a three-person team per build is deliberate overcapacity in service of the date.

5. How we get clients

Status, stated without decoration: Nikolytics has no proven, repeatable acquisition channel yet. Every past client arrived through luck or through an existing client's orbit. The current channel plan is therefore a set of deliberate experiments with honest measurement, run in this order, funded only by collected cash.

5.1 The funnel every channel feeds

Conversation → **Launch-Risk Teardown** → **Blueprint** → **Sprint**. No channel sells the $250,000 build directly; every channel starts a conversation that earns the next step.

- **The Launch-Risk Teardown:** a 12-point review of the prospect's existing stack, architecture, or vendor quotes; 90 minutes live with Nikola, then a scored 2-3 page written risk memo and a 5-minute recorded walkthrough they can forward to a cofounder or board. **Capacity: 5 per week, and the cap is real** (it rides alongside live delivery). Pricing ladder: first five free under four spoken conditions (they act on it, they give blunt feedback, a named review if it deserves one, and introductions to two or three funded founders); then $1,000, $2,000, $3,000 per five delivered; list price $5,000. The memo tells the whole truth, including "your stack is fine, do not rebuild yet." A Teardown that recommends against us is a completed, successful Teardown.
- **Scope wall:** the Teardown diagnoses what exists. It never produces a spec, prototype, checklist, architecture for a new build, or credit. Anyone asking for those hears, verbatim: "That is the Blueprint, it costs $25,000, and every dollar credits toward your build within 60 days."

5.2 Founder-led LinkedIn (primary experiment)

Reality first: Nikola's LinkedIn has been dormant since college. Sequence, in order, no skipping:

1. **Profile rebuild** (headline, about, featured, positioning for platforms, not automations). Inputs come from the content identity session (queued).
2. **Account warmup.** A dormant account jumping to high-volume outreach gets restricted by LinkedIn and reads as spam to prospects. Volume ramps gradually within platform limits.
3. **Outreach at honest volume.** Daily counts are set after warmup, sized inside the founder time budget (below) and LinkedIn's real connection-request caps, not the 100-per-day book default (that figure assumed an existing warm list across phone, email, and DMs, which we do not have).

Benchmarks we plan against, from verified 2025-26 outreach data: cold automated outreach to US founders replies at roughly 6%; founder-to-founder, personalized, content-supported outreach should beat that floor, and our first 100 conversations will tell us by how much. Every outreach message is personalized; templates are skeletons, never sent verbatim.

5.3 Content (the trust engine)

We sell a $250,000 service with, today, no public case studies. Content is how a stranger becomes comfortable enough to take a first call, and it silently nurtures every conversation the other channels start (Hormozi reports 78% of his own clients had consumed at least two long-form pieces before booking; treat that as directional, not our data). Direction: narrate real work (build artifacts, decisions, scar tissue), give far more than we ask, and route asks to the Teardown.

The full content system (identity, pillars, cadence, profile copy, first two weeks of posts) is defined in a dedicated session and will be appended to this manual. Two rules are already binding: **INTIIMI is never referenced in any content**, and **Paragons content requires Shane's written permission plus the standing disclosure line** (Section 9).

5.4 Referral partners

Referrals are our highest-conviction channel because they transfer trust we have not built publicly yet.

Mark (fundraising agent; works with founders raising capital and with investors). Terms agreed 2026-07-04, to be papered before the first introduction:

- $2,500 when a referred Blueprint collects; $22,500 more when the referred build's signing payment collects ($25,000 total per build).
- A qualified referral is: a funded US founder, seed to Series B, with a platform need, delivered as a **3-way introduction** (never a name and a number).
- Fees are paid on collected cash only, never on signatures.
- **Disclosure is mandatory:** the referred founder is told a referral arrangement exists. Hidden fees, discovered later, would burn Mark's network and ours; disclosed, this is a normal partnership.
- A performance kicker (higher fee after repeated collected builds) is available later; referral compensation is paid forever and never capped.

Standard referral fees for everyone else: $10,000 per closed build, $2,500 per Blueprint-only close, same collected-cash and 3-way-intro rules. The ask-at-purchase script runs at every signing: "Who else in your investor's portfolio is fighting a platform build?"

Shane / Paragons orbit: an equity-aligned founder-client willing to co-create content and make introductions. All Paragons referral and content activity waits on the written barter agreement and permission gates in Section 9.

5.5 Reddit (gated experiment)

Origin fact, logged honestly: Shane found Nikola on an automation subreddit while Nikola was looking for a mentor. We classify that as luck, not a mechanism. Reddit re-enters only if we identify communities where $250k-plus buyers demonstrably exist; there is no general-purpose subreddit grinding.

5.6 Paid ads (locked)

Locked until Q1 2027 at the earliest, behind three gates that all must be green: **Gate A, cash** (a separate ads account holding $60,000 funded only by collected platform payments); **Gate B, tracking** (a seeded lead travels ad-click to closed-won with source intact in the CRM); **Gate C, content** (90+ consecutive days of publishing and 3+ pieces that each produced engaged leads; ads are made from proven organic winners, never written from scratch). Ads will point at the Teardown and the Blueprint, never directly at the $250,000 Sprint (the test math only works at the entry-offer level). Budget ceilings and CAC governors for the agency are in Section 12; derivations are in the Founder Appendix.

5.7 Time budget and tracking

The founder time budget is 3 hours per day for outreach plus content, total. All quotas size to this number. Delivery hours are protected; the two engineers are never pulled into marketing work; the contract designer contributes up to 3 hours per week of content polish.

Tracking is mandatory from day one. Every lead carries a `source` field (warm / content / cold / referral:[name] / paid). The weekly numbers reviewed every Monday: reach-outs sent, reply rate, conversations started, Teardowns delivered against the 5-per-week cap, Blueprint conversations opened, Blueprints signed against the 2-slot cap, builds signed against the 3-slot fill level, referral introductions received, and the four demand-study fields from Section 3 logged on every conversation.

6. How we sell

The sales motion is founder-led and conversation-based. There is no sales team and no buy button for the Sprint; every close happens inside a meeting that already exists for delivery.

1. **The Teardown session is the first meeting.** It ends with the truth: either "your plan is fine, do not rebuild yet" in writing, or specific risks, three of which typically live in undefined scope. The bridge line, delivered as written: no audit fixes undefined scope; only a co-signed spec does; that is the Blueprint.
2. **Premium is presented first, beside the Blueprint.** The framing question: "Are you here for a document or a launched platform?" Most funded founders answer "platform"; the Sprint is presented with the Blueprint as the safety rung, never the other way around.
3. **Terms are presented Full-Send first**, with the $85,000 prepay incentive visible, then the Builder's Split. The price never moves in either.
4. **On any "no," the Commitment Ladder runs, in order:** (1) financing rails ("would you rather I decide your payment terms, or you decide?"; a financed client pays us 100% at signing and receives Full-Send incentives, because for us that is payment in full); (2) the Builder's Split, deposit reason stated openly; (3) the temperature check ("1 to 10, how badly do you want this live in 30 days?"), where 8+ routes to timing structures (Reserve: pay the $25,000 Blueprint today, lock waitlist priority and the 60-day credit, set the kickoff date against their round close) and 7 or below routes to the Blueprint as a genuinely different, smaller purchase; (4) for a hard no, a complimentary teardown of their current vendor quotes, which sells nothing and schedules the next conversation. Both ladder ends leave the prospect inside the funnel, never outside it.
5. **The Blueprint Debrief converts.** Scheduling rule with no exceptions: Debrief-to-kickoff must be 7 days or less, or the build is closed paid-in-full at the Debrief itself. (The credit expires at day 60; the cohort calendar supplies the honest deadline.)
6. **We never discount, we add value.** The negotiation chip is a bonus (for example, attaching the Launch Concierge Command against three 3-way introductions), never a price cut. The 54% deposit does not soften.
7. **Every signing triggers the referral ask** (Section 5.4) within the first 48 hours while goodwill peaks.

Ladder scripts are v1 and pending live-fire testing; wording will be tuned against real conversations and logged.

7. How we deliver

The delivery calendar, standard build (dates from kickoff):

Day	Event
Before kickoff	Blueprint phase: extraction sessions, spec, prototype, architecture doc, Acceptance Checklist co-signed
0 (Monday, cohort)	Kickoff: accounts under client logins, sandboxes open, named team introduced
3	Live staging URL exists; daily deploys and daily 3-minute demo videos begin
Week 1	Integration War Room: the scariest third-party APIs attacked first
14	Staging milestone demo (split-plan payment 2 lands here)
~25	Launch Plan Review: launch choreography set
≤30 (internal target ~14-18)	Go-live against the Acceptance Checklist; final split payment
~34	Handoff meeting: instruments, docs, keys confirmed; post-launch options presented
+60 days	Founders' Shield warranty window (extends to 180 on a guarantee event)

Capacity rules, enforced without exception: 3 concurrent builds; a client's launch week closes before that team's next build begins; one shared post-launch feature-week lane of one team-week per month across the whole business, tracked on a published **Week Ledger** capped at 6 outstanding owed weeks; the named maintenance engineer (the "tenth seat") services warranties and Evergreen plans, capped at 6 active Evergreen plans and 4 active Extended Shields until a second maintenance hire. When any cap is reached, the corresponding offer pauses publicly and a numbered waitlist runs. Caps are treated and advertised as inventory.

Our side of the guarantee: the concierge does the chasing, blocker questions are answered within 4 working hours during US business overlap, the three decision gates are booked at signing around the client's calendar, and internal milestones carry padding so the client experiences early, never late.

8. The money machine (current and staged)

The intended path of one client relationship, with activation status:

Step	Offer	Price	Status
1	Teardown	free to $5,000 ladder	**Live now**
2	Blueprint	$25,000, credits 100% within 60 days	**Live now**
3	Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint	$250,000	**Live now**
4	Commitment Ladder (terms change, price never)	n/a	**Live now** (scripts v1)
5	Traction Block: two post-launch Iteration Weeks + 12-month Extended Shield	$80,000 prepaid	**Staged: Q4 2026 gate**
6	Product Engine: ongoing feature development	$16,000 per 4-week cycle (bulk: 5 cycles + 1 free at $80,000)	**Staged: gated on a dedicated iteration pair being hired**
Year 2	Evergreen renewal, Engine annual terms, Founding Partner conversations	varies	Future

Principles that govern the machine:

- **Client-financed acquisition.** The payment structure (full prepay or a 54% deposit) means one signed client's collected cash funds acquiring and servicing the next ones. This is why the deposit never softens and why paid-in-full is always presented first.
- **Two bars for every client relationship**, checked with honest accounting: 30-day collected cash must exceed the cost of getting and serving that client (minimum bar); one client's 30-day profit should fund getting and servicing two more (the growth bar). Cash that lands after day 30 is real and welcome and is never counted against the 30-day bar.
- **The upsell is planted, not sprung.** The Traction Block is mentioned at the day-14 demo and priced at the Launch Plan Review, deliberately separated from any payment event. Continuity (the Engine) is offered last, at the go-live handoff.
- **Nothing is ever the same thing for less.** Downsells change terms or scope, never price. Free coverage (Shield, Evergreen), paid warranty (Extended Shield), and paid new work (Engine, Iteration Weeks) have a hard scope wall so nothing double-sells.
- **Staged offers stay staged.** Selling the Block or Engine before their gates (capacity tooling, dedicated hires) would break the honesty mechanics that make the whole model work. Detailed specs live in the working documents and activate on their gates, with Nikola's sign-off recorded in the decision log.

Worksheet-level numbers (scenario profits, CAC governors' derivations, attach-rate assumptions) live in the Founder Appendix.

9. The rebrand: positioning, messaging, and website rules

What the rebrand is

From "automations by Nikola" to **Nikolytics: premium custom platform builds for funded US startups, delivered with certainty mechanics no one else offers.** Same company, same delivery strength, one flagship, US positioning, premium pricing.

The competitive frame (from verified July 2026 research)

- The speed frame ("fast MVP, fixed price, you own the code") is crowded: shops sell 14-to-30-day builds from $4k to $25k, and one credible firm owns "30-day MVP with free scoping" almost verbatim. **We do not lead with speed alone and we never use the word "MVP."**
- Nobody found in the research delivers $250k-scope platforms live in 30 days. The scope-speed-certainty combination is our unclaimed ground; it is also unproven, which is why proof production (below) is a priority.
- $250,000 is 5-25x above the entry prices a comparison shopper sees on directories. The pitch sells the outcome and the certainty mechanics, never hours (at our speed an hourly framing reads as expensive; the correct comparison is two senior hires at $400k/year plus six months of recruiting, or six months of agency discovery while the launch window closes).
- Buyers see free scope calls everywhere. The Blueprint is paid on purpose; the response to "they scope for free" is the difference in what is delivered (a co-signed spec, prototype, architecture doc, and checklist, credited in full).

Messaging rules (binding for the agency, the website team, and everyone else)

1. Lead with pressure transfer and certainty, in plain language. Every such claim is immediately backed by its mechanism (named team, staging URL from day 3, client-owned accounts, checklist, audit, the guarantee).
2. Banned: "MVP"; invented or implied proof of any kind; unverified statistics; superlatives without a mechanism; em dashes; dollar figures paired with time promises in names or headlines.
3. **Proof discipline (the current hard constraint):** Nikolytics has zero publishable case studies, zero publishable testimonials, and zero cleared quantified client outcomes today. Nothing may state or imply otherwise. The honest move, used openly: say exactly that, and show the mechanisms that remove the need for trust. Proof slots exist in the site structure and stay empty until real assets clear their gates.
4. **Paragons publish gates:** Shane's written permission per the co-content barter agreement; the athlete figure verified and precisely phrased; USOPC-protected terms ("Team USA", Olympic marks) handled as descriptions of fact with no implied endorsement; every co-post carries the standing disclosure line: "I hold a small equity stake in Shane's umbrella company."
5. **INTIIMI: never referenced. Anywhere. In anything.** No hints, no anonymized case studies, no "an eight-figure-funded client." The NDA conversation may change this later; until the decision log says so, the rule is absolute.
6. Tone: plain, direct, specific, confident without theatrics. Numbers beat adjectives. If a sentence would survive on a hype-agency's site unchanged, rewrite it.

Website team brief (summary; full brief follows the messaging session)

- The prior landing HTML is discarded; do not reference it. Copy will be human-written; the site is designed deliberately, not generated.
- The page's job: one primary action (book the Teardown), a secondary action (start the Blueprint), and a conversation door for the Sprint. No buy button for the Sprint, on purpose.
- **Required live mechanics, non-negotiable because the copy's honesty depends on them:** the build-slot fill level ("X of 3"), Blueprint seats ("X of 2"), the next cohort date, and the Teardown's current pricing rung must all be real and current. A stale counter is worse than no counter. These ship before any outbound wave points at the page.
- The guarantee appears verbatim, with its conditions. The $1.5M Founding Partner tier's visibility is undecided (open item); nothing renders until decided.

10. Operating principles

The mindset behind our decisions, stated as rules. If a choice contradicts one of these, escalate to Nikola before acting.

1. **Sell certainty, deliver early.** Internal targets beat promised dates by a wide margin (2-week target inside a 30-day promise). Clients experience early, never late.
2. **Honesty as mechanics.** Caps are real numbers, published. Waitlists are numbered and dated. Sell-outs are announced. Proof is real or absent. We would rather show an empty proof section than a padded one.
3. **The price is the price.** No discounts, ever. Deals sharpen by adding value. Terms flex through structure (financing, split, the Blueprint), never through the number.
4. **Spend only collected cash.** No plan, hire, or campaign spends money that has not landed. Growth is client-financed by design.
5. **Assumptions are labeled.** Every unmeasured number carries its label in writing. Replacing assumptions with measured data is scheduled work, not a hope.
6. **Decisions get logged or they did not happen.** The decision log is the memory of the company. Contradicting a logged decision requires flagging it, not silently overriding it.
7. **Everything traceable.** Public claims trace to verified facts; internal claims trace to the facts sheet; strategy traces to the frameworks and research on file.
8. **Paid relationships are disclosed.** Referral fees and equity stakes are stated to the people they concern, in writing, every time.
9. **NDA discipline is absolute.** One client engagement is never referenced. When unsure whether something is covered: it is, until Nikola says otherwise.
10. **Speed of response is part of the product.** Blocker questions within 4 working hours during the build; replies to live prospects lead the next morning's queue.
11. **One niche, one flagship, one ladder.** New service ideas, new segments (foundations included), and new channels wait for their written triggers.
12. **Simple scales.** When choosing between a clever mechanism and a simple one, the simple one wins unless the numbers say otherwise.

11. Roles

Role	Who	Owns	The one number that defines success
Founder	Nikola Popović	Positioning, sales conversations, Teardowns, content, final decisions, delivery oversight	First new-system client closed and delivered
Engineering (2)	Internal employees	Build execution, staging cadence, module library	Builds live within the internal 2-week target
Design (contract)	Contract designer	Content polish (≤3h/week), build design assets	Assets delivered inside delivery timelines
Referral partner	Mark	Qualified 3-way introductions to funded founders	Collected builds from his introductions
Marketing agency	To be selected (triggers in appendix; learn-then-leave arrangement)	Channel execution we can learn and internalize	CAC within the stated governors, honestly tracked
Website team	Engaged by Nikola	The site per Section 9 brief	Live mechanics accurate; page converts to Teardown bookings
Future: content/outreach assistant	Trigger-gated hire	Research batching, list hygiene, memo first drafts	Engaged leads per month at target cost
Future: iteration pair, second maintenance engineer, fourth build team	Trigger-gated hires	Product Engine, cap raises	Their gate metrics (appendix)

External partners operate inside this manual: the messaging rules (Section 9), the honesty mechanics (Section 10), and the tracking requirements (Section 5.7) are contractual expectations, not suggestions.

12. Canonical facts sheet

Every number this company uses, with its status. **Verified** = happened, provable. **Decision** = chosen and logged. **Assumption** = planning placeholder, replace with data. **Gated** = true but restricted (publish gate or NDA).

Offers and prices (all: Decision)

Fact	Value
Flagship price	$250,000 fixed, never discounted
Stack stated value / bonus stated value	$465,000 / $297,000 ($275,000 always-on)
Full-Send prepay incentive	$85,000 stated value
Builder's Split	54% / 26% / 20% = $135,000 / $65,000 / $50,000
Blueprint	$25,000; 100% credit within 60 days; max 2 concurrent
Teardown	5/week cap; free x5 then $1,000/$2,000/$3,000 per five; list $5,000
Traction Block (staged)	$80,000 prepaid
Product Engine (staged)	$16,000 per 4-week cycle; bulk 5+1 at $80,000
Founding Partner anchor	$1,500,000; one client per year
Guarantee	Live-in-30, conditional service-based, pause-not-void
Capacity	3 build slots; 1 team-week/month post-launch lane; Week Ledger cap 6; Evergreen cap 6; Extended Shield cap 4
Kickoffs	First and third Monday, cohort-based; 72-hour waitlist claim window
Referral fees	$10,000/build, $2,500/Blueprint standard; Mark: $2,500 + $22,500 on collected cash
Paid-ads CAC ceilings (for agency planning)	≤ $48,000 per build acquired (≤ $68,000 with Block attached); Blueprint CAC ≤ $28,800 hard, $15,000-$20,000 working target; LTGP:CAC floor 3:1

Company facts

Fact	Value	Status
Team today	Nikola + 2 engineers + 1 contract designer	Verified
Platforms built to date	~5, largely by Nikola personally	Verified (Nikola statement)
Delivery speed	Full platforms shipped by ≤3-person teams in 2 weeks to 1 month	Verified (Nikola statement)

Fact	Value	Status
Internal ship target	~2 weeks against the 30-day promise	Decision
American Paragons build	$250,000, closed, platform launched and live	Verified
Paragons platform usage	~1,000 Team USA / Olympic athletes (~1/3 of USA's athletes) + hundreds of supporters	**Gated: Nikola's estimate; verify figure + Shane's written OK + USOPC-safe phrasing before any public use**
Paragons Performance	Built; awaiting marketing funding	Verified, gated same as above
Sport Endorse	$5,000 integration, closed	Verified
The Players Impact	$7,500 integration, pending	Verified
Large NDA engagement	Exists; six-figure quote; **never referenced**	NDA
Pipeline evidence of demand	~$870k closed + quoted	Verified, internal use only
Steering metric	First new-system client closed, delivered, documented	Decision
Founder acquisition time	3 hours/day (outreach + content)	Decision
LinkedIn	Dormant since college; rebuild precedes volume	Verified
Marketing budget intent	~$200k over 12 months, funded only by collected platform payments	Decision (intent, not committed spend)
Warm CAC $5,000; flagship fulfillment $35,000; Blueprint fulfillment $12,000	planning figures	**Assumption**
Cold LinkedIn reply baseline ~6% (US founders, automated outreach)	external research, floor not forecast	Verified (external)
Blueprint-to-build conversion ≥60% in 60 days	health target, no industry data exists	**Assumption/target**

Open items ledger (owner in parentheses)

1. Audit vendor shortlist + fixed per-build cost (Nikola)
2. Named maintenance engineer confirmation before the third client signs (Nikola)
3. Blueprint public advertising go-date (Nikola)
4. Live fill-level indicator on the site before any outbound wave (website team)
5. Wrapper/name test design, after LinkedIn rebuild (session)

6. Founding Partner website visibility (Nikola)
7. Financing partner for ladder rung 1 (Nikola)
8. Week Ledger tooling before the first Block sale (staged, Q4 2026)
9. Iteration Week cost confirmation before the first Block (staged)
10. CRM choice so source data never migrates (Nikola, before outreach starts)
11. Shane co-content barter agreement signed before the first Paragons post (Nikola)
12. Mark's terms papered before the first introduction (Nikola)
13. INTIIMI disclosure conversation with the founder (Nikola)
14. Paragons athlete figure verification (Nikola + Shane)
15. LinkedIn profile rebuild (content identity session feeds it)
16. Content identity session (queued, dedicated)
17. Demand-study logging instrument: the four fields wired into the CRM (with item 10)
18. Legal review: deemed acceptance, cancellation policies, financing disclosures, referral paperwork (Nikola)

13. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Zero-Surprise Platform Sprint	The $250,000 flagship: custom platform live in production in 30 days on client-owned infrastructure
Blueprint	$25,000 paid scoping sprint (spec, prototype, architecture doc, Acceptance Checklist); credits 100% toward a build within 60 days
Launch-Risk Teardown	The diagnostic lead magnet: 12-point review, 90-minute session, scored written memo
Debrief	The meeting where Blueprint results are presented and the build decision is made (≤7 days before kickoff, or close PIF there)
Acceptance Checklist	The co-signed list defining "done"; powers the guarantee and the final payment
Swap Token	Client right to replace one unbuilt feature with a comparable one mid-build at no cost (two per build)
Glass Box	The transparency bundle: live staging from day 3, daily deploys, daily demo videos, named team
Full-Send / Builder's Split	Payment in full at signing (with $85k incentive) / the 54-26-20 split plan
Live-in-30 Guarantee	The conditional service guarantee quoted in Section 4.1
Founders' Shield / Extended Shield	Free 60-day defect warranty / its paid 12-month extension (inside the Traction Block)
Evergreen Codebase Plan	12 months (24 on Full-Send) of dependency updates and security patching
Momentum Sprint	Full-Send bonus: one post-launch feature week within 90 days
Traction Block	Staged $80,000 upsell: two Iteration Weeks + Extended Shield
Iteration Week	One team-week of post-launch feature work at build speed
Week Ledger	The published capacity ledger for all post-launch weeks; cap 6 outstanding
Product Engine	Staged continuity offer: $16,000 per 4-week cycle of feature development
Founding Partner Build	The $1.5M anchor tier, one client per year, Nikola-led
Cohort	A kickoff date batch (first and third Monday)
Fill level	The published count of occupied build slots ("X of 3")
PIF	Paid in full
3-way intro	A referral made by introducing both parties in one thread; the only referral format that counts
A-C-A	Acknowledge, Compliment, Ask: the reply structure for outreach conversations
BAMFAM	"Book a meeting from a meeting": no conversation ends without the next one scheduled

Term	Meaning
LTGP:CAC	Lifetime gross profit to customer-acquisition cost; floor 3:1
CFA	Client-financed acquisition: collected client cash funds acquiring the next clients
The four demand-study fields	Trigger, objections, last-vendor story, source; logged on every conversation